

complaints. "It has now become a marketing tool to talk about work." Kapoor on his part didn't bother as his detractors deemed him too skinny or hairy to be a hero or one who lacked a presence or had small eyes. Instead, he worked on turning his weaknesses into strengths. "Now people talk about my looks, my hair and how expressive my eyes are."

As his peers have slowed with age, Kapoor's enthusiasm has only increased. It's what makes him get up every day with a spring in his step to go on set and collaborate with the likes of Ranbir Kapoor (*Animal*, upcoming 2023) or Hrithik Roshan (*Fighter*, upcoming 2024). In 1989, INDIA TODAY dubbed him "the joker in the pack". It's a moniker he continues to own with aplomb. There's no magic potion. "You have to love what you are doing," he says. "Even when you are tired and exhausted, you have to fulfil all your commitments, have that energy and make people happy." In the audience's contentment lies Kapoor's own. ■

Suhani Singh

ENTERTAINMENT

His Dark Materials

Sudip Sharma is back on Netflix with *Kohrra*, a crime drama set in Punjab



Love is a Dog from Hell. The title of Charles Bukowski's book of poems is brandished on the wall of an aspiring rapper in the new Netflix series, *Kohrra*. For Sudip Sharma, the show's creator, it is also the guiding light of the investigative crime drama set in Punjab. The love in this six-episode series comes in many forms and hues; it's messy, it's challenging and it also kills. But at the core of the Punjabi-Hindi show is the patriarchy and toxic masculinity that lingers like a mist and the generational trauma it can cause. It leads to one of Sharma's favourite lines in the show, "*tussi bande hi zahar ho* (all you men are just poison)".

For Sharma and the show's two writers—Gunjit Chopra and Diggi Sisodia—the whodunit is a ploy to examine "what goes into the making of it [toxic masculinity] and why people behave the way they do", says Sharma. "Even when we are projecting a hard front, it stems from some kind of inferiority complex or vulnerability that we are trying to hide."

Nearly all the characters have chinks in their armour and secrets to hide. The two protagonists—police officers Balbir (an excellent Suvinder Vicky) and Garundi (Barun Sobti in an unseen avatar)—are grappling with personal crises as they try to solve the death of an NRI groom-to-be. There's Balbir's daughter (Harleen Sethi), who has left an unhappy marriage only to return to an unhappier home with a domineering father. Manish Chaudhari and Varun Badola play feuding brothers and demanding dads brought together by a tragedy. Through these characters, *Kohrra* shows us a diverse Punjab—one inhabited by rich expatriates; the industrial belt of Ludhiana; and the one of youth rebellion as seen through the characters of a jilted lover and rapper, and a disgruntled son.

Kohrra is Sharma's third consecutive long-format credit after Amazon's Paatal Lok and Netflix's Mai

Kohrra continues Sharma's narrative journey, which explores the world of crime and focuses on the immorality that pervades society. "I get drawn to things that we brush under the carpet," he says. For Sharma, the characters' imperfections and faults make them relatable. "Even in the sagas of gods, why are weaknesses pointed out? It is for us to learn from. Having flaws doesn't stop you from achieving your true potential as long you accept and overcome them," he says.

The show is also Sharma's third consecutive long-format credit—after Amazon's *Paatal Lok* (2020) and Netflix's *Mai* (2022). It is a space he finds "very liberating". "Now when I look at it, I started with 'short stories' [writing films], and with shows, it is like writing fully-formed 'novels'," he says. So content is Sharma that he no longer finds writing films as enticing. "The film scene is very dead. If it is theatrical, then it has to be necessarily nonsensical or so broad-based that it doesn't interest people like me," he says. "I hope I don't have to write one at least until the scene changes." For now, Sharma finds solace in the amoral beings he creates for web series. ■

Suhani Singh

